Iraqi War Poetry
By Various Authors

NOTE: This is way to long for one poetry presentation; but each poem is so incredible, it has been left up to the performer to pick and choose the items they'd like to include.

INTRODUCTION

In late January 2003, in response to an invitation to a symposium by Laura Bush to celebrate "Poetry and the American Voice," Sam Hamill declined; a longtime pacifist, he could not in good faith visit the White House following the recent news of George W. Bush's plan for a unilateral "Shock and Awe" attack on Iraq. Instead, he asked about 50 fellow poets to "reconstitute a Poets Against the War movement like the one organized to speak out against the war in Vietnam...to speak up for the conscience of our country and lend your names to our petition against this war" by submitting poems of protest that he would send to the White House. 1,500 poets responded within four days . . . These are their heartfelt responses to the War in Iraq.

Afterward, We May Want to Know What Happened

by Ralph Angel

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Amazing. We're all still here,
and everybody's talking at once.
But each moment works against us—we can't
hear everything—and gets us through the hour
in buses and taxis, airplanes
carving the sky, the slow shade of a cloud
that creeps through an open market with promises of
nighttime striking a deal with the daylight.

No. We can't see everything,
but when did looking convince us?
Now we don't want these flowers,
and we curse the vendor for showing them.
It's all regret, the fish on the ice,
the baskets of potatoes and green beans, all
regret, until regret too

is demolished. From the dust and rabble
steel skeletons stand in the grandeur of distance
and glass skin. And today, again,
we've hurried to Century City, but we arrive

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forever early, unable to live up to our destination—
neither shades nor galoshes, but
the myth of afternoon.

Perhaps that's enough. Perhaps
it's all true. These designs of ourselves, and the wind,
somewhere else. Among corporate towers
and modular dunes, among vacant, dazzling plazas
we're all just here, and each voice
is a tiny fissure in the earth's veneer.
And each voice calls to us, calls in the spirit of
a beggar with something to give.

GOOD CLEAN FUN

by Diane di Prima

It's terrorism, isn't it, when you're afraid to answer
the door for lack of
a Green Card
afraid to look for work, walk into the hospital when yr

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child is sick,

and what else than terrorism cd you call those smallpox
blankets we gave the
Indians
the trail of tears, the raids on Ghost Dancing tribes
It's terrorism when you're forbidden to speak yr
language
paddled for it, made to run a hundred laps in the snow
in your thin & holey sneakers. What do you call it
when you're locked in yr high school classroom, armed
policemen
manning the halls? Isn't it terrorism to force a young
woman
to talk to her parents abt her clandestine love
the child she will or will not carry? Is it terrorism
to shoot striking onion workers (1934), pick off AIM
members one by one?

What happened to the Hampton family in Chicago his
bed;

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would you call that terrorism? Or the MOVE kids in Philadelphia
bombed in their home. Or all the stories we don't know
buried in throats stuffed w/socks, or pierced w/bullets.
Wd you call it terrorism, what happened at Wounded Knee
or the Drug Wars picking off
the youth of our cities twenty years ago now;
you know the names.
What was COINTELPRO if not terrorism? What new initials are they calling
it today?

Is Leonard Peltier a victim of terrorism?
Is Mumia Abu-Jamal?

Is it terrorism if you are terrified
of the INS, the IRS, the landlord, yr boss, the man
who might do yr job for less?
if you're scared of yr health insurance
no health insurance

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scared of yr street, yr hallway, scared every month
you might not get to the 1st and the next measly check?

Is it terrorism to take food from hungry school-kids?
To threaten teenagers who still have hope enough
have joy enough to bring babies into this mess?

How has terrorism touched you, shaped your life?
Are you afraid to go out, to walk in yr city, yr suburb, yr countryside?
To read, to speak yr own language, wear yr tribe's clothes?
Afraid of the thin-shelled birds w/twisted necks
poisoned by nitrates, by selenium?
Afraid that the dawn will be silent, the forests grey?

Is it terrorism to fill the Dnieper w/radiation?
or heat the ionosphere w/magnetism "to see what will happen"?
A wonderful weapon, they say, it will perturb
the weather pattern, disrupt communications

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Who are the terrorists in the lumber wars?
(the water wars are coming)
And we haven't even talked about AIDS and cancer.

Is the assault on native intelligence & good will
that we call the evening news
anything other than an act of terror?

What was the Gulf War but terrorism
wearing the death mask of order? < one big car bomb it
was
the guys who drove it dying now
one by one
Is acid rain a form of terrorism? (Think for yourself.)
Is GATT or NAFTA anything but a pact among brigands
and their back-up men?
How long before they fight over the spoils? Who'll do
their fighting for
them?

Is Alan Greenspan perhaps the biggest known & named

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of our terrorist leaders, here, nurtured here,
trained here

the dark design of whose hearts makes
Hutu & Tutsi
Croat & Muslim & Serb
mere diversionary tactics before the onslaught

BULLETIN

by Diane di Prima

It is happening even as you read this page. By the time you finish reading this it will be over.

She will have left the hotel and disappeared. He will have eaten the pills. That one will slip and crack her skull on the floor. That one will go out in a driveby shooting.

halfway around the world the bombs are dropping

As you read these words it is already too late. 200,000 children will have starved. One of them held the Jewel

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in his brain, another could cure plagues with her breath.

As you read this line one thousand have died of AIDS.
They die alone hidden in furnished rooms. They die on the ground all over Africa.

halfway around the world the bombs are falling

Do not think to correct this by refusing to read.
It happens as you put down the paper, head for the door.
The ozone reaches the point of no-return

the butterflies bellyflop, the last firefly, etc.
Do not think to correct this by reading.

The bombs burst the small skull of an Arab infant the silky black hair is stuck to your hands with brains.
W/bits of blood. There is less shrieking than you would expect

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a soft silence. The silence of the poor, those who could not afford to leave. Drop flowers on them from yr mind, why don't you? "I guess we'll have to stay and take our chances."

They die so silently even as we speak

Black eyes of children seek eyes of the dying mother
bricks fall dirt spurts like fountains in the streets.
In the time you fill a cup they die of thirst.

In the time it takes to turn off the radio.
Not past, not future

The huts are blazing now. South of Market a woman ODs with an elegant sigh. No more no less than is needed.

halfway around the world the bombs are dropping

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To the Forty-third President of the United States of America

by William O'Daly

Mr. President, our history speaks to us, the history of Chile
and China, El Salvador and Nicaragua, Somalia, Puerto Rico—
today, our solemn duty is to defy your willful aggression,
to parse provocative words and habits, your heroic battle
to distract us. Perhaps you think God will protect us
from the religious zealots who sanctify your rule,
from your opportunism and the race renewal,
the investiture you have assumed because, as
always, it is not yours. Let me ask
an obvious question.

If we are to establish peace
and security for our nation, must we not do
everything in our power to end
the beginnings of war, must we not allow
our imaginations to craft a lasting peace?

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Are not the children you would choose
to incinerate our own? We try on masks
to trick our isolated, frightened selves,
to propagate our sacred uncertainties
among the children of this blue planet,
a world we create and ruin every day.

Mr. President,
where do we walk, where may we sit down,
where can we work or rest, weep or pray,
what field does a man sunder and seed
in a country living only in memory, dying
every day at the hands of those who profess
to love her most? They say God loves America,
and that this "old bitch gone in the teeth" is
heaven on earth; in preemptive violence,
in obstinacy, in entitlements for the rich,
this murdered land, this, the people's
earth, is our reward for being right
no matter how wrong we are.

What "urge and rage"
thrives in the American heart, that so many cheer

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this obsessive, unilateral madness?

Even through

precise layers of glass, the TV peddling

a thrilling efficiency, we cannot see them,

the ghosts that inhabit our malnourished

statistics, inhospitable closets, cold kitchens

where we eat meat and raise goblets of wine

to celebrate our belief that they are not like us.

I want to spend more time with my daughter,

my five-year-old, I want to see her, to know

she is alive. It is her "evening of the morning,"

she is just fine, though she implores me to tell her

the "acommitation of naked truth."

I imagine

Iraqis, weakened by sanctions, spending time

with their children. What do they play together,

what makes them laugh, what crude medicine

do parents spoon down fevered throats, when

they too are roused from nightmares of fragile

necklaces of bone, slung around the necks of

American fighters whose hearts we camouflage?

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Who will witness the small charred bodies floating

in the Tigris, children writhing in pain, in smoking rubble,

in the ruins of Bab al-Wastani or the Mirjan Mosque,

severed limbs and glazed eyes that last night

followed their favorite story by candlelight?

Mr. President,

what does it mean when you say Saddam Hussein,

Butcher of Baghdad, official liar, terrorizes himself?

If he brings terror upon himself, will our dark angels

exterminate him or his already wounded people;

and would you answer Mr. Korb: What if Kuwait grew

carrots, what if Iraq's

main exports were chick peas and cotton shawls

destined for American women

longing for the exotic?

To be honest,

I have forgotten from what we must abstain,

yet we know how to prevent conception. *"C'est la vie,"*

you say, saddled up, ready to ride with your posse

across oil fields just like those in Texas.

It appears the one thing we cherish

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more than petroleum or our children
is the greased machinery of destruction.

* *Notes*

1. "old bitch gone in the teeth": Ezra Pound, from "Hugh Selwyn Mauberley"

2. "urge and rage": Anne Frank, from The Diary of a Young Girl (1947; tr. 1952), entry for 3 May 1944

3. "evening of the morning": Kyra Gray O'Daly

4. "acommitation of naked truth": Kyra Gray O'Daly

5. Bab al-Wastani: the last remaining of the renowned gates of Baghdad

6. Mirjan Mosque: ancient mosque, completed in 1358

7. "If Kuwait grew carrots we wouldn't give a damn." Lawrence Korb, former U.S. assistant secretary of defense, on the motives for "Operation Desert Storm"

8. "The war on terror involves Saddam Hussein because of the nature of Saddam Hussein, the history of Saddam Hussein, and his willingness to terrorize himself." George W. Bush

9. *"C'est la vie"* : "Either they are with us or not. Either one is fine. *C'est la vie."* An aide to George W. Bush, quoting him

10. "I know some in Europe see me as a Texas cowboy with six-shooters at my side. But the truth is I prefer to ride with a posse." One senior Bush aide, recalling President Bush's comment to Czech President Vaclav Havel in Prague (Fall 2002)

If There Were No Days, Where Would We Live
by Primus St. John

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The heart line begins
on the thumbless side of the palm
traveling horizontally under the fingers,
when it is clear & deeply etched
you have deep emotions...
so the war is over, my love,
and we have killed enough of them,
torched their homes
trampled their fields
mutilated their arms
burned their legs
harvested their ears
and wore them like dark pearls
drove them crazy
made night a sure sign
of death
their schools, lost canyons
with nothing blowing through them
and an exact count of
dead mothers
dead fathers

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dead children
and all that was given
taken away.
What do you do now
with the hunger
and the poverty glaring in their faces?
St. Teresa
would have probably kissed it,
but we were not saints
we were soldiers
hiding in the enemy's world.
How many times
must I be dipped into the water
to be a child again?

Portrait of George W. Bush as a Cowboy, or:
America's Foreign Policy of Peace
By Terry Tempest Williams
(Warning: This is a rant and may not be good for your mental health)

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Old myths die hard as they say in the American West, and perhaps no lie is as captivating as the romance of the American Cowboy. Talk about a sacred cow that lives on in Texas. What I want to know is how George W. Blue-blood Bush has spun his identity to the point where we believe him when he says his preference is "home on the range" rather than commander-in-chief." Karl Rove, his trusty genius-in-residence, actually said, "Given the choice of Wall Street over Main Street, the President would choose Main Street every time." Yup, he's just a regular 'ole guy in a Stetson and levis who just happens to live in The White House.

He is a man who wears a Stetson and levis with a relentless appetite for war..
Yee-haw! Ride e'm cowboy, all the way to Iraq. Forgive me, but that's what it feels like every day in the USA, where conservative talk show host Rush Limbaugh tells his viewers to "relax, we'll get our war" as he called the anti-war demonstrations anti-American demonstrations fueled by communists and environmental wackos. Never

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mind that freedom of speech is a tenet of American democracy or that dissent is what this country was founded on in the first place. Bush and his conservative army of listeners wants blood, not ours, but theirs. And theirs is no longer Osama Bin Laden and Al-Qaeda, but rather Saddam Hussein and Iraqi dissidents who are a more stable target, not prone to hiding in caves or shape shifting. We want to show what we've got by way of military prowess, in case the world has forgotten.

Just the other day, Dan Rather exposed the latest military scheme called "Shock and Awe," a strategy developed with the hopes it would "have this simultaneous effect rather like the nuclear weapons at Hiroshima, not taking days or weeks but minutes" to destroy the enemy. 300 to 400 cruise missiles would be deployed at once, more than the number launched during the entire 40 days of the first Gulf War. "The sheer size of this has never been seen before, never been contemplated before," a Pentagon official said. "There will be not be a safe place in Baghdad," "The horror and

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destruction will be so vast and fast it will inspire nothing but shock and awe." Within minutes, blood-soaked handkerchiefs will be waving from the rubble begging for mercy, and then presto, the war will be over. Nice and neat, clap the dust off our hands. In and out, mission accomplished.

One lariat thrown around the neck of Saddam Hussein, and it's the end of the rodeo. George W. Bush will wave his white hat to the crowd as he takes a bow from the saddle of his fast-riding horse in the middle of the arena.

"Shock and awe." Read all about it. Barrel riders secure the Iraqi oil for themselves in record time.

It is time to expose the myth of the American Cowboy for what it is, a lie designed to perpetuate the rugged loner who takes the law into his own hands..
It doesn't matter if in truth, he's just a hired hand of the people who pay him. Or that his real home is not on

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the range, but simply moving through with no sense of responsibility to the folks who live there. What matters is that he can speak in simple verse and smoke his Marlboro cigarettes with style at the same time he rides off into the sunset with his silver pistols lashed to his thighs as he feels his trustworthy horse between his legs. Bodies left behind or broken fences never mended don't trouble him. He is the perfect image for American individualism. Take what's yours and move on.

Of course we can "go it alone," says George W. to the increasing world-wide opposition to war in Iraq. That's the American way. "You're either with us or against us." As the president so eloquently said, "I don't do nuance."

The cowboy president doesn't talk details, he just points his pistol in the general direction of fear and starts shooting off his rhetoric like those three quick bullets, "Axis of Evil," that were heard around the world. North Korea flashes news of nuclear weapons and then it's our turn to reply that our missiles are bigger than

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their missiles and now it's no longer rodeo time, but Super Bowl Sunday, with the United States Cowboy on the starting line with George as quarterback, his arm cocked and ready for a military touchdown.

George W. Bush loves a good game. The problem is -- war is not a game. And for those of us who do not view this man as our legitimate president, how do we get his attention?

I used to think democracy was a good place to start, but since September 11, and the creation of the new Department of Homeland Security, our civil liberties are being whittled and eroded away. Our voices raised in question are discredited and quelled. Fear has replaced reason. Confrontation has overruled contemplation. Entitlement has replaced respect as we watch environmental laws slashed and sensitive wildlands ravaged for their oil and ancient trees in the name of national security. The "war on terror" is first being waged here at home.

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To those of you living in Europe, we thank you for your leadership of resistance. We thank you for gathering in the hundreds of thousands in London, Florence, Madrid, and Paris, showing us what is possible and inspiring our own demonstrations. And our numbers in the anti-war movement in America are growing. We thank you for crying foul on what we Americans have only dared to think to ourselves until now. And we thank you for your prayers and we pray with you believing there is a "conservative compassion" that can stay the violence of war. What we are learning from you is that those with a memory of war on their own soil are the first to call for patience and pause...

Perhaps, it will continue to be this kind of pressure from countries with a memory of fascism and a history of empires that have risen and fallen, that in the end will remind our cowboy culture in America that the poster with burnt edges, “Wanted Dead or Alive,” has never translated well in international law. America right now,

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under the Bush Regime, has a very destructive, call it foreign, policy for peace.

What I fear in America right now is this: War is the body bag flown home with a nice note from the president that reads, "She served our country well in the fight for freedom." War is also amnesia, so that in the grief of that moment, Americans will choose to believe him and find ourselves imprisoned by our own arrogance.

THE HEARTH

by C. K. Williams

1.

Alone after the news on a bitter
evening in the country, sleet slashing
the stubbled fields, the river ice;
I keep stirring up the recalcitrant fire,

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but when I throw my plastic coffee cup
in with new kindling it perches intact
on a log for a strangely long time,
as though uncertain what to do,

until, in a somehow reluctant, almost
creaturely way, it dents, collapses,
and decomposes to a dark slime
untwining itself on the stone hearth.

I once knew someone who was caught in a fire
and made it sound something like that.
He'd been loading a bomber and a napalm shell
had gone off; flung from the flames,

at first he felt nothing, and thought
he'd been spared, but then came the pain,
then the hideous dark--he'd been blinded,
and so badly charred he spent years

in recovery: agonizing debridements,

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grafts, learning to speak through a mouth
without lips, to read Braille with fingers
lavaed with scar, to not want to die--

Though that never happened. He swore,
even years later, with a family,
that if he were back there, this time allowed
to put himself out of his misery, he would.

2.

There was dying here tonight, after
dusk, by the road: an owl,
eyes fixed and flared, breast
so winter-white he seemed to shine

a searchlight on himself, helicoptered
near a wire fence, then suddenly
banked, plunged, and vanished
into the swallowing dark with his prey.

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Such an uncomplicated departure;
no detonation, nothing to mourn;
if the creature being torn from its life
made a sound, I didn't hear it.

But in truth I wasn't listening, I was thinking,
as I often do these days, of war;
I was thinking of my children, and their children,
of the more than fear I feel for them,

and then of radar, rockets, shrapnel,
cities razed, soil poisoned
for a thousand generations; of suffering so vast
it nullifies everything else.

I stood in the wind in the raw cold
wondering how those with power over us
can effect such things, and by what
cynical reasoning pardon themselves.

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The fire's ablaze now, its glow

on the windows takes the night even darker,

but it barely keeps the room warm.

I stoke it again, and crouch closer.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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